

SPARKLY SPLENDOR

CHRIST THE REDEEMER

One of the Seven Wonders of the World, Christ the Redeemer stands 40-metre tall on Corcovado mountain in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil. The statue has its towering presence on the 2,300 feet peak of the mountain since 1931. It is not only a land mark monument of Rio, but a symbol of the warmth of the people of Brazil.

Similarly, many Indian cities are rich in historical monuments and landmarks that have become synonymous to their existence.

Delhi, the national capital, exudes a strong presence of the Mughal architecture in its monuments and buildings. The Red Fort, built by Shahjahan in the 17th century, is a delight to one's imagination. Mumtaz Mahal, Rang Mahal (Palace of Colours), Khas Mahal (Emperor's Palace) and Diwan-e Khas (Hall of Private Audience) are a must see! Purana Qila or the Old Fort represents the inner citadel of Dinpanah, a city founded by Humayun. One can almost smell the ancient stories oozing from the corners of the fort. Qutub Minar, the highest stone tower in India, heralded the birth of slave dynasty. India Gate also stands tall to remind us of the 90,000 Indian soldiers who sacrificed their lives during the World War I.

As India Gate is synonymous to Delhi, the Gateway of India is to Mumbai. Built in 1924, it has become a favoured gathering spot, attracting huge crowds. Facing the impressive Gateway is the luxurious Taj Mahal Palace, an important landmark of the city. It has more than 500 guest rooms and a grand central staircase. Besides, Haji Ali Dargah and Mahalaxmi Temple are important religious landmarks, especially the latter during the festival of nine nights (navratra).

Bangalore is also rich in historical monuments. Vidhan Soudha, the magnificent structure houses state legislature and the secretariat and is the administrative building of the State Government of Karnataka. The grand palace of Tipu Sultan is made up of teak wood with floral patterns on the walls and ceilings; it is a huge tourist attraction. The Bangalore Palace — built by Chamaraja Wodeyar, Maharaja of Mysore in 1887 — is also worth exploring. Its Gothic windows, turreted parapets, battlements, fortified towers and arches immediately catch attention of the visitors.

Almost all the cities of modern India are replete with monumental heritage; whether you talk about Hawa Mahal and Jantar Mantar of Jaipur or the Charminar of Hyderabad. The list is endless.

LINKING TRACKS

THE GREAT WALL OF CHINA

This great wall, extending up to 6,700 kilometres, was built to link existing fortifications into a united defense system and better keep invading Mongol tribes out of China.

Our metro cities are well on their way to becoming global metropolis and world-class cities. Long distance and poor connectivity might soon be problems of the past in suburban India.

Scores of projects are in the works to ensure a well-integrated transportation network that will be a great facilitator in reducing the journey time by a considerable margin. Taking into account that the future lies in mass rapid transit, Delhi is expanding the metro rail network and working on the bus rapid transit (BRT) system. The Delhi Metro Masterplan-2021 aims to provide a network of 413.8 kilometres by 2020, thereby inter-connecting Noida-Delhi-Gurgaon for a hassle-free travelling. Dedicated bus corridors are being built to ensure rapid transit for 60 per cent of the city population that travel by bus. Eastern and western peripheral highways are being developed to ease the pressure on intra-city roads.

Inspired by the national capital, Mumbai has also initiated the construction of metro lines. Work has already begun on the Versova-Andheri-Ghatkopar corridor. The Bandra-Worli Sea Link Project is expected to be ready by December 2008. This link will ease the pressure on Mahim Causeway and provide an additional link connecting the western suburbs with Mumbai. The existing suburban railway system, considered to be the lifeline of the state, is being further strengthened. The Mumbai Urban Transport Project, which aims at improving the traffic and transportation system in the city by 2009, has already been executed.

Chennai boasts of excellent road transportation. While inner ring-road caters to the metropolitan area, most of the arterial roads lead to national and state highways. Elevated roadways are proposed along several sections to reduce travel time. In addition to the Chennai suburban railway system, an underground elevated surface metro railway transport system has been planned for the future urban transport requirements. Along with the modernisation of the Chennai International Airport, another airport is being constructed at Sriperumbudur at an estimated cost of Rs 2,000 crore.

Kolkata already has an extensive railway network that not only connects various parts of the city with one another, but also to the rest of India. The station at North Kolkata has been a new addition to existing two major railway stations at Howrah and Sealdah. New railway lines are being laid to further improve the inter-district connectivity. The Government of West Bengal is also looking into the feasibility of light rail transit system.

With plans to make travelling convenient, hopefully our metros are building a better future sans traffic woes.

